

KDENZ GTM DE-RISK PLAN: EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Prepared: February 4, 2026

For: Kdenz Founder (Triple Board-Certified Physician)

Context: B2C AI communication coaching | MVP shipped | \$0 primary research completed

Goal: Unlock 5 critical GTM decisions with evidence in 14 days

THE SITUATION: WHAT YOU'VE BUILT VS. WHAT YOU KNOW

✓ What You've Validated (Secondary Research: 16,000+ words, 60+ citations)

- **Technical feasibility:** MVP works (Chrome-only, real-time filler detection, AI coaching, playback)
- **Competitive landscape:** Yoodli, Orai, Poised analyzed (features, positioning, gaps)
- **ICP hypothesis:** Early-career managers (Option B) beats job seekers (Option A) on LTV (3-5x)
- **Positioning framework:** Three angles defined (Gap Model, Diagnosis Model, Coach Model)
- **Pricing benchmark:** \$12.99-28.99/mo based on competitor analysis
- **Behavioral science:** Volitional diagnostics framework (skill gap, motivation gap, commitment gap)

✗ What You Haven't Validated (Primary Research: Zero)

- **Will your ICP pay \$12.99-28.99/mo?** (Assumption based on Noom, not Kdenz users)
 - **Do managers have weekly difficult conversations?** (Drives subscription vs. event-based pricing)
 - **Does volitional diagnostics messaging resonate?** (Gap Model locked as "validated" but never tested)
 - **Will 15-25% convert at 3rd session paywall?** (Projection, not data)
 - **Does physician credential build more trust than tech founder?** (Untested assumption)
 - **What's actual 30-day retention: 60% or 30%?** (Determines LTV and unit economics)
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THE RISK: YOUR GTM STRATEGY RESTS ON 6 UNVALIDATED ASSUMPTIONS

Assumption	Source	Impact if Wrong
15-25% freemium conversion	Noom/wellness app benchmarks	Unit economics collapse. If actual is 8%, LTV drops 50%; CAC ceiling drops proportionally.
Managers practice weekly	Logic ("difficult conversations are daily/weekly")	Retention model broken. If usage is monthly, subscription doesn't work; need event-based pricing.
Gap Model positioning resonates	Locked as "validated" without user testing	Messaging repels users. If users reject "competence gap" framing, trial signups crater.
\$12.99-28.99 pricing is optimal	Competitor benchmarking (Yoodli, Orai)	Price too high or too low. Users may anchor at \$9.99 (Duolingo) or expect coaching-tier (\$100+).
Physician credential differentiates	Founder belief (no A/B test)	Positioning wastes opportunity. If tech workers trust "ex-Googler" more, physician angle backfires.
60% retention at 30 days (managers)	Projection based on "habit-forming use case"	LTV fiction. If retention is 30%, not 60%, projected LTV of \$200-800 becomes \$80-150.

Bottom Line: Every financial projection (LTV, CAC, conversion rate) is based on analogies to other products, not evidence from your target users interacting with your product.

THE PLAN: 14 DAYS TO UNLOCK 5 CRITICAL DECISIONS

Decision 1: ICP Confirmation (Managers vs. Job Seekers vs. Pivot)

Research: User interviews (n=15) + diary study (n=8, 2 weeks) + cohort retention analysis

Question: Do managers have 2+ difficult conversations/week to justify subscription?

Success Metric: ≥60% report weekly practice-worthy conversations

Kill Criteria: <40% weekly opportunities → pivot to event-based pricing or interview-only positioning

Decision 2: Pricing Validation (\$12.99 vs. \$9.99 vs. \$19.99)

Research: Price sensitivity survey (n=50) + A/B paywall test (3 variants)

Question: What price maximizes conversion without leaving money on table?

Success Metric: ≥20% conversion at \$12.99; diagnostic messaging lifts conversion ≥5pp

Kill Criteria: <15% conversion → freemium broken; pivot to 7-day trial + paid

Decision 3: Positioning Framework (Gap vs. Diagnosis vs. Coach)

Research: Message testing survey (n=80) + qualitative interviews (n=12)

Question: Which messaging angle drives highest trial intent + resonance?

Success Metric: Clear winner (≥60% "resonates strongly") with measurable trial intent lift

Kill Criteria: Tie or reverse from locked choice → default to Diagnosis (most differentiated)

Decision 4: Paywall Trigger (3rd Session vs. 7-Day vs. AI-Gated)

Research: Cohort A/B test (n=300, 100/variant) via MVP

Question: Which trigger maximizes conversion without premature drop-off?

Success Metric: 3rd-session cohort ≥20% conversion within 14 days

Kill Criteria: All cohorts <12% → freemium model doesn't work; need trial-based model

Decision 5: Retention Strategy (Weekly Trend vs. Streaks vs. AI Quality)

Research: Feature correlation analysis (MVP data) + preference survey (n=60)

Question: Which features drive Week 2+ return?

Success Metric: Progress chart correlation ≥ 0.25 ; streaks < 0.15

Kill Criteria: All features weakly correlated $\rightarrow$ retention problem is value/motivation, not features

TWO-WEEK EXECUTION CALENDAR

WEEK 1: ICP VALIDATION + POSITIONING DISCOVERY

Day	Activity	Deliverable	Time	Owner
Mon (Day 1)	Research design + recruitment	Interview script, survey, A/B landing page, recruit 15 managers + 50 survey respondents	4 hrs	Founder
Tue (Day 2)	Competitor paywall teardown	Yoodli/Orai/Poised paywall matrix, pricing insights	3 hrs	Founder
Wed (Day 3)	User interviews (Batch 1: 5)	Interview notes, key quotes, pattern synthesis (preliminary)	3 hrs	Founder
Thu (Day 4)	Interviews (Batch 2: 5) + survey + A/B test launch	5 more interviews, survey live, landing page live, ads running	4 hrs	Founder
Fri (Day 5)	Interviews (Batch 3: 5) + diary study kickoff	Final 5 interviews, 8 diary participants, synthesis memo	4 hrs	Founder

Day	Activity	Deliverable	Time	Owner
Sat-Sun (Day 6-7)	Data collection (passive)	Survey responses (→50), landing page traffic (→200), diary logs	0 hrs	Auto

Week 1 Output: 15 interviews complete, 50 survey responses, 200 A/B landing page visitors, 8 diary participants logging Week 1

WEEK 2: RETENTION + MONETIZATION VALIDATION

Day	Activity	Deliverable	Time	Owner
Mon (Day 8)	Interview synthesis + cohort analysis	ICP confirmation, retention curves (managers vs. job seekers), feature correlation	5 hrs	Founder
Tue (Day 9)	Survey analysis + A/B landing page results	Messaging winner, credential winner, pricing insights	4 hrs	Founder
Wed (Day 10)	Paywall trigger experiment design	3-variant A/B test (3rd session vs. 7-day vs. AI-gated) ready to launch	3 hrs	Founder
Thu (Day 11)	B2B buyer discovery (optional)	3 buyer interviews (L&D, Sales Enablement,	2 hrs	Founder

Day	Activity	Deliverable	Time	Owner
		HR), buyer hypothesis		
Fri (Day 12)	Churn survey + diary study check-in	10-15 churn survey responses, diary Week 2 data, churn driver analysis	3 hrs	Founder
Sat-Sun (Day 13-14)	Final data collection (passive)	Paywall A/B test running, diary study wraps	0 hrs	Auto

Week 2 Output: Retention curves validated, messaging + pricing locked, paywall test running, churn drivers identified

Day 15 (Monday): SYNTHESIS + GO/NO-GO DECISIONS

Activity: Compile all research into decision memo + go/no-go matrix

Deliverable: Final Research Synthesis Report (10-15 pages) + Updated GTM Strategy (1-pager)

Time: 6 hours

Owner: Founder

Decisions Locked:

1. ☒ ICP confirmed (managers) OR pivot signal (job seekers, hybrid, or new segment)
 2. ☒ Pricing tier (\$12.99, \$9.99, or \$19.99)
 3. ☒ Positioning (Gap, Diagnosis, or hybrid)
 4. ☒ Paywall trigger (3rd session, 7-day, or AI-gated)
 5. ☒ Retention strategy (features to prioritize for Week 2+ retention)
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BUDGET BREAKDOWN

Item	Cost	Purpose
User interview incentives	\$200	15 interviews @ \$20 Amazon gift card (optional but increases show rate)
Survey respondent incentives	\$100	50 survey responses @ \$2 each (Prolific, Upwork, or email list)
A/B landing page ads	\$200	200 visitors (100/variant) @ \$1 CPC (LinkedIn, Reddit, or Facebook)
Diary study incentives	\$200	8 participants @ \$25 for 2-week commitment
SensorTower (optional)	\$99	Competitor revenue estimates (or use free public data)
LinkedIn Recruiter (optional)	\$200	B2B buyer targeting (or use cold outreach)
TOTAL (Max)	\$999	Budget-conscious: \$500 (skip optional tools, self-recruit)

Bootstrap Alternative: \$0 budget option

- Self-recruit via LinkedIn, email list, Reddit (no incentives)
 - Use free tools (Google Forms, Google Analytics, manual competitor teardown)
 - Skip SensorTower (use public data: Crunchbase, reviews, pricing pages)
 - **Trade-off:** Lower response rate, slower recruitment, less statistically robust
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KILL CRITERIA: WHEN TO PIVOT

If This Happens...	It Means...	Do This Instead
<40% managers report weekly conversations	Subscription model broken	Pivot to pay-per-session (\$2.99/session) or interview-only positioning
<15% freemium conversion	Paywall doesn't work	Switch to 7-day free trial → paid (\$9.99/mo); kill freemium
Tech credential wins OR no difference	Physician angle doesn't differentiate	Lead with product ("AI speech coach"), not founder story
All paywall triggers <12% conversion	Freemium model fundamentally broken	Pivot to paid-only with 7-day money-back guarantee
Manager retention <40% at 30 days	ICP is wrong OR product doesn't solve problem	Interview churned managers; identify blocker (feature, value, or market fit)
<15% job seekers return post-hire	Hybrid funnel is churn trap	Treat job seekers as separate segment; don't blend messaging
Time/commitment dominates churn (>50%)	Session length is blocker	Reduce default to 30s; add "quick practice" mode

Key Principle: Define failure criteria *before* running research to avoid confirmation bias.

IMMEDIATE NEXT STEPS (TODAY)

1. Review This Plan (30 min)

- ☐ Adjust priorities based on your constraints (time, budget, access to users)
- ☐ Pick 5 research gaps to execute first (recommend: #1, #2, #3, #6, #8)
- ☐ Decide on budget: \$0 (bootstrap) vs. \$500 (hybrid) vs. \$1,000 (full)

2. Draft Research Instruments (2 hours)

- ☐ Customize interview script
- ☐ Build positioning message survey (3 variants, 8 questions)
- ☐ Create A/B landing page mockups (physician vs. tech founder)

3. Recruit Participants (2 hours)

- ☐ Email beta users: "Can I interview you for 30 min? \$20 Amazon gift card"
- ☐ Post in LinkedIn: "Early-career managers: Help me build a communication coaching app"
- ☐ Post in Reddit (r/managers, r/sales, r/careeradvice): "Research participants needed"
- ☐ Target: 15 interviews + 50 survey responses

4. Launch Week 1 (Monday)

- ☐ Conduct first 5 interviews (Wednesday)
- ☐ Launch survey + A/B landing page test (Thursday)
- ☐ Kick off diary study (Friday)

You now have everything you need. Execute.